



This article clears the air about the general perception that Android apps must be written only in Java. Advances in the mobile development environment have made it possible to create hybrid apps without working with Java, by using cross-platform tools such as PhoneGap.

Android is currently the most widely used mobile operating system in the industry, across the world. It came into existence in 2007 and, ever since, there has been a boom in Android-based smartphones. This has not only resulted in a large number of devices and apps entering the market, but has also created a whole new world of programming for developers. The Android API is exposed in Java, and those who are well versed with Java do not find it much of a challenge to develop Android apps. But for those who do not know Java, it is difficult to jump into Android app development. This is why new ways to develop Android apps are being sought, which has paved the path for hybrid mobile apps.

The mobile development environment has evolved greatly since 2007 and has witnessed a number of new

trends. Among them is the birth and evolution of hybrid mobile apps. Mobile apps are broadly categorised as native apps, Web apps and hybrid apps (see Figures 1 and 2). Native apps are developed using the underlying native technology of the mobile platform. For instance, in our case, native Android apps are developed using Java. Web apps, or specifically, mobile Web apps are those that are optimised to be viewed from smartphones. These are normal Web applications developed using HTML5, CSS and JavaScript, and have been modified to be rendered perfectly in various form factors, including those at the lower end in the smartphone space. Hybrid apps utilise the best of both worlds. It is the general opinion that Web development is easier with technologies like HTML5, CSS3 and JavaScript, and the developer base is much